

■ By **Baradan Kuppusamy**  
in Kuala Lumpur

**M**alaysian Tamils, descendants of 19th-century indentured labourers from Tamil Nadu, last showed their anger in 1941 when thousands of rubber plantation workers downed their tools in the district of Klang, some 30 km east of the capital Kuala Lumpur, to protest against hardship and low wages. Now nearly seven decades later, an estimated 20,000 Tamils protested in a big way again on November 25, condemning official discrimination, inhumane treatment and demanding a fair share of the nation's wealth. "Official discrimination and neglect has severely marginalised us," says Uthayakumar Ponnusamy, a lawyer and the man behind the Hindu Rights Action Force (Hindraf), the organiser of the protest. "We are trapped in a cycle of poverty, crime, drugs and alcoholism. They don't treat us as citizens; they treat us as garbage—smelly, unwanted and better forgotten."

Strong words indeed but these are normal for Ponnusamy, a London-trained lawyer who set up shop in Kuala Lumpur in 1994 and has spearheaded many campaigns, including a recent one to stop the demolition of temples in Malaysia. His latest campaign, rallying "oppressed and suppressed" Tamils around the banner of Hinduism, is potentially the most explosive. "The campaign pits the Tamil minority against the Muslim majority and it is worrying," says Samy Vellu, a longtime government minister and president of the Malaysian Indian Congress, a moderate Indian party that is a minor partner in the ruling National Front coalition government led by the dominant United Malays National Organisation (UMNO). "He spreads lies and works up racial emotions...it is explosive and dangerous. Where is it going to lead?"

UMNO president and Prime Minister Abdullah Badawi, a moderate Muslim practising inclusive Islam, is also angry with Hindraf, which is a coalition of 30 Hindu organisations formed in 2006. Like Vellu, Badawi dismisses Ponnusamy's accusations as "pure lies", but has sought a report into the improvement of conditions for Tamils

by employing them in the civil services, providing training in skills for Tamil youth and offering small business loans. He has also quietly ordered the demolition of temples to be curbed until further investigation. But Badawi has angered civil rights leaders by threatening to use security laws against protesters, laws that allow for detention without trial for any number of years. With a general election widely expected by March next year, Badawi is weighing his moves. A hard crack-down would see minority votes fleeing to the Opposition. A soft approach, his aides say, would embolden the "fanatics and extremists" to demand the sky.

The face-off is a potential minefield for India, where the Tamil population is clamouring for some form of Government intervention to help their fellow Tamils in Malaysia. A mild statement of "concern" from New Delhi last week was immediately rebuffed by Kuala Lumpur, indicating the deep sensitivities involved (see box). But the Hindraf campaign has struck a chord among the Tamil masses, going by the huge numbers that turned up for the protest. The turnout shocked many Malaysians. "We can't understand why so many Indians are angry," says Law Minister Nazri Aziz. "We stand by the

**PUSHED TO THE WALL:**  
Tamil protesters being  
teargassed in Kuala Lumpur



# FIGHTING FOR

Ethnic Indians, marginalised by the Bhumiputra policy of the Malaysian



millions of Indians who stayed at home (instead of protesting on the streets). We are with them."

The shock is all the more telling because Malaysia is a land of plenty in many ways. It successfully transformed itself from a backwater country getting by on rubber and tin, into a dynamic economic powerhouse. Annual per capita income has soared from under US\$300 to over US\$3,000 (Rs 1.18 lakh) in 20 years. The economy is among the top 20 in the world, and nearly three million legal and illegal foreign workers remitted \$6 billion (Rs 23,600 crore) in 2006 to their families across Asia, including India. But